

Switch to Autopilot

Create macros to automate repetitive tasks and you can sit back and let your computer do the grunt work for you!

IMAGING: Ram

Computing has made several everyday tasks simpler for many of us. From accounting software to manage finance, to word processors that take much of the tedium out of writing letters, computers have been quite successful at reducing the monotony of performing repetitive and often boring tasks. However, there still remain many tasks that we end up performing over and over again on a PC. For instance, every bootup is followed by the predictable ritual of launching the Internet connection, starting up your favourite site in a browser and then running Outlook Express to check for new mail.

Even Windows, which most of us would consider a sophisticated and user-friendly operating system, doesn't offer tools that could provide some much needed relief in this area. True, there is the Windows Task Scheduler, but it isn't very powerful and doesn't let you perform more complex tasks such as launching multiple programs, or copying specific files at predefined times. The only way to do this in the past has been through the use of programs that require you to get a hang of fairly complex scripting languages.

Today, however, there are several applications that let you automate some pretty complex Windows tasks. One of the better ones around is Macro Angel v1.5.2, which has a simple wizard-based interface that lets you get the job done without having to first get a degree in programming.

Understanding the task

What an automation tool does is to create a task. A task involves steps (or actions) that are executed in a sequence which is specified in advance. These actions could be anything from launching a specific utility, to switching between windows, sending keystrokes to an application or even performing a complex series of mouse movements and clicks.

Tasks can be set to run either at a specific time or on the occurrence of a specific event, which is called a trigger. A triggering event could be the pressing of a particular key combination or even the appearance of a dialog box, application or window.

Working with the Task Wizard

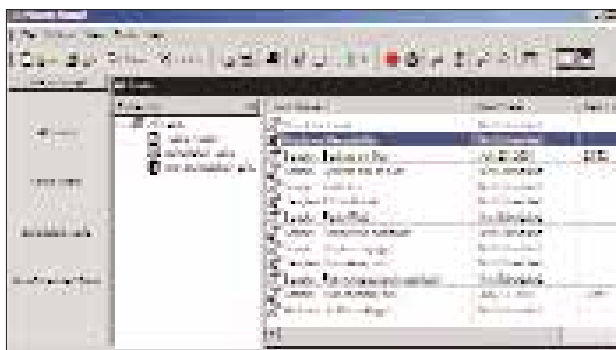
Creating a task is very simple in Macro Angel, which provides us with a wizard that does this in five relatively simple steps. Clicking on the **File > New Task** menu in the main screen of the Macro

Angel interface launches the first screen of the 'Task Wizard'.

STEP 1 Task name: At this stage you need to specify a unique name for your task. You can also enter detailed information describing the task in this window. Other options include an 'Enable Task' checkbox that can be used to disable a task at any time.

STEP 2 Recurrence: If you have a timetable in mind then here is where you need to enter specifics about the time intervals at which the task needs to be executed. You are also given the option of setting a task to run only on specific days of the week.

STEP 3 Date and time: This step is optional and necessary only if you choose to schedule the task in the previous screen. You need to key in the date and time when the task will first be launched. This lets the software keep track of whether everything's progressing as per schedule. It also lets it calculate the frequency of tasks that have been configured to run repeatedly. In case the execution of a task is delayed for some reason—perhaps the computer was turned off at the prescribed time—



The Macro Angel interface is well designed and very easy to use